SYSDESIGN REFERENCE

Consistent Hashing

Core concepts, reference diagram, tradeoffs, and interview prompts.

Map keys to a ring so membership changes move only a bounded fraction of keys.

VERSION 1.0 REVIEW

REVIEWED THROUGH 2026-07-18

STATUS HUMAN REVIEW REQUIRED

SYSDESIGN / CONSISTENT-HASHING

SYSDESIGN

Consistent Hashing

CORE IDEA

Map keys to a ring so membership changes move only a bounded fraction of keys.

Reference architecture decision chain

01	02	03	04
Virtual Nodes	Weighting	Replication	Membership Propagation

Decisions to defend

+ Virtual nodes
+ weighting
+ replication
+ membership propagation
+ and hotspot mitigation.

Failure modes to test

+ Uneven rings
+ correlated replicas
+ and churn during rebalancing.

Interview flow

- [ ] Clarify users, critical paths, and non-goals
- [ ] Estimate only scale that changes a decision
- [ ] Define API, data model, and source of truth
- [ ] Draw synchronous and asynchronous paths
- [ ] Pressure-test timeout, retry, overload, and recovery
- [ ] Close with tradeoffs and one alternative

Deep-dive drill

Consistent Hashing

Probe	What a strong answer makes explicit
How does the design behave during a regional dependency failure?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
Which metric reveals the first bottleneck?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
What consistency does the user actually observe?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.
How would the design change at ten times the traffic?	Requirement, decision, cost, failure behavior, and observable metric.

Data questions

+ Partition key
+ Versioning
+ Uniqueness
+ Retention
+ Reconciliation

Operations questions

+ SLO
+ Backlog
+ Capacity
+ Alert
+ Failover test

DESIGN DISCIPLINE

For every box: which requirement justifies it, what cost does it introduce, and what happens when it fails?

PUBLISHING STATUS

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